

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

In the rugged badlands of Bihar's Champaran zone, Ramadhar Yadav's pedigree evokes awe, thanks to his father Vasudev Yadav, a former bandit who once allegedly 'pioneered' the kidnapping industry in Bihar. The senior Yadav, on whose head both the Bihar and Uttar Pradesh governments had put a price, may have surrendered in May 2008 but his reputation (over 75 cases of murder, dacoity, abduction and extortion) still triggers goosebumps in Champaran.

In his village, Vasudev's 40-year-old son Ramadhar, who contested

on government bodyguards, the Bagaha superintendent of police (SP) has maintained that Ramadhar and his family feel "unsafe in the aftermath of Vasudev's surrender". Perhaps the bandit's family seems to suggest that they were "safe" as long as the crime lord dominated the badlands; and the SP finds no harm nodding to their logic. The alacrity with which the police bodyguard was made available to Ramadhar—an order to this effect was issued only a day after Vasudev's surrender—also suggests a "deal" between the police and Vasudev.

Since then Ramadhar, who is not from the Below Poverty Line category,

Security FARCE

An increasing number of relatively rich and powerful persons are being provided with police security by the government. At last count, there were 137 individuals whose well-being is now an official matter.



2005 Assembly polls from Dhanaha in West Champaran, perhaps lives up to this reputation. He is often seen in the company of four private gunmen. But Ramadhar still feels "unsafe". Ramadhar admits he too was an accused in "one or two minor cases".

In reply to INDIA TODAY's RTI query

enjoys free government protection. But that's not the only jarring note from the Bagaha police. They have provided a free bodyguard to an "apolitical" person because of his "political rivalry" with MLA Poornawasi Ram.

In Bihar, there are 137 private individuals with free government pro-

tection. Some of these men have two bodyguards. Even by conservative estimates, Bihar spends at least Rs 2 crore every year on the salaries of these security personnel. The issue raises eyebrows as almost all these private individuals with free bodyguards are otherwise capable of pay-

